dominant theme in the literature. It certainly was for contemporaries. The New Europe noted in 1920, 'The Foreign Office seems incapable of asserting its rights to control policy, and has irresponsible competitors, not only in the Garden Suburb of Downing Street, but in the War Office, the Admiralty and the India Office'.[24]

On initial viewing, then, it would appear that Kerr, Sir Maurice Hankey (head of the Cabinet Secretariat), Lloyd George and even officials of the War and India Offices were all more influential in creating Britain's foreign policy after 1918 than the Foreign Office itself. And yet there is reason to believe that actually the Foreign Office was just as important in the post-war period as it had always been. Perhaps we have previously been too quick to accept at face value the testimony of certain contemporaries. G. H. Bennett argues that the tone of historical debate on British foreign policy in this period was essentially set by Lord Beaverbrook, whose biography of Lloyd George laid the idea of a dictatorial prime minister who had almost entire control of foreign affairs.[25] In Beaverbrook's work 'Foreign Secretary and Foreign Office recede to the distant horizon'.[26] Writings by contemporaries appeared to support this concept of a presidential-style foreign policy and historians have been happy to take this idea and run with it.

As has been shown more recently, however, the relationship between the Foreign Office and other government departments was quite complex. For example, despite contemporary apprehension, the Cabinet Secretariat was actually of little challenge to the Foreign Office: the Secretariat held no executive or administrative function and had no authority to take the initiative in any matter.[27] And while it has been taken for granted that the Garden Suburb was a threat to the Foreign Office, it is hard to evaluate the influence of Kerr and his colleagues on policy-making, since their contact with Lloyd George was unofficial.[28]

Part of the problem may have been that by nature Curzon was highly alert to even the slightest indication that his authority might be being questioned; therefore, as foreign secretary Curzon found the very existence of the Garden Suburb unsettling. Such sensitivity thus led to an exaggeration of the threat posed by the likes of Hankey and Kerr. Curzon's issues were not